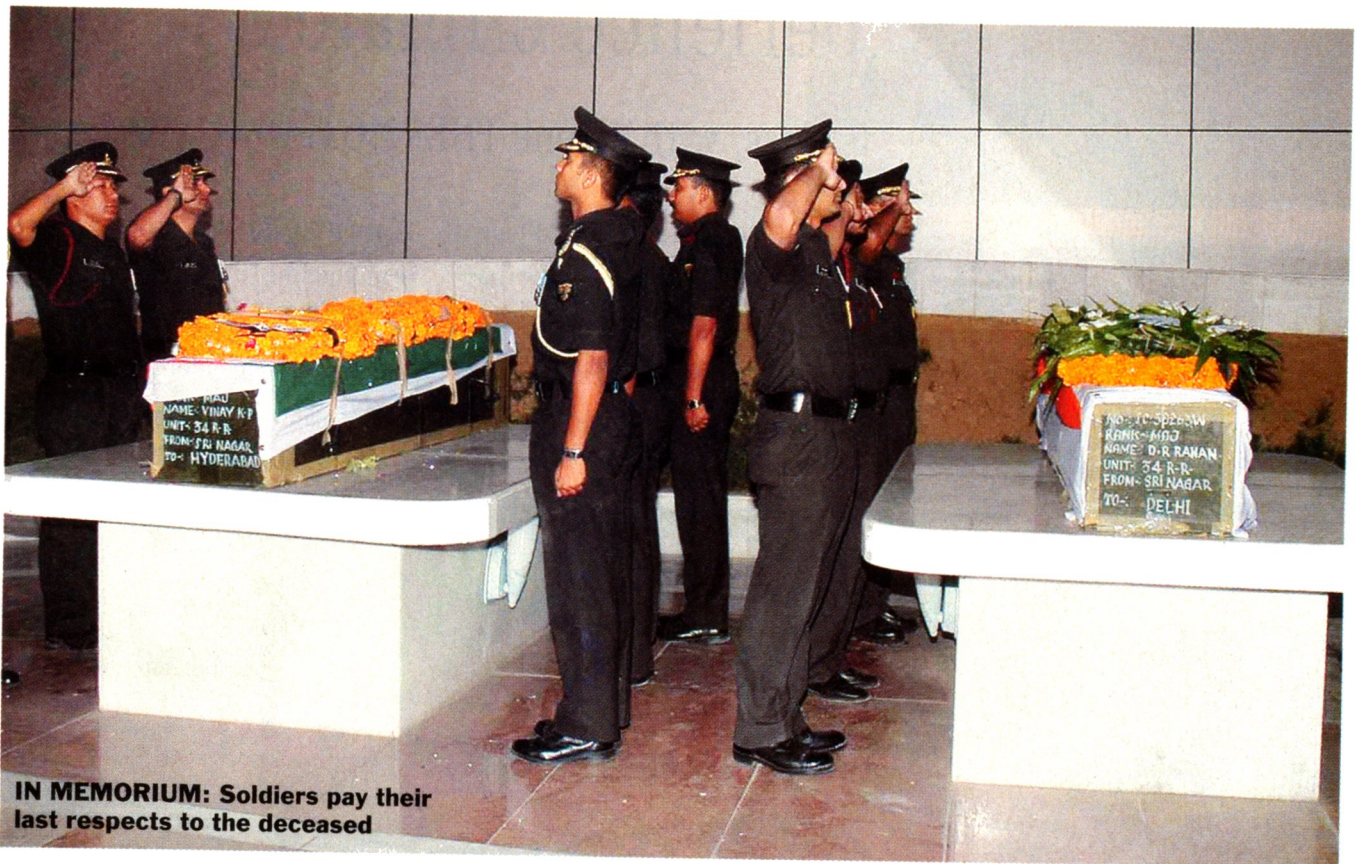




IN MEMORIUM: Soldiers pay their last respects to the deceased

A Farewell to The Fallen

A ceremonial guard set up after Kargil has one task alone: to honour those killed in the line of duty

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

The station headquarters in Delhi Cantonment buzz with activity with phones ringing and soldiers snapping at attention. An officer works three phones, speaking to army units across the country while thumbing through a flight schedule. This is a military operation with a difference.

A group of over 50 armymen—officers, buglers, a ceremonial guard of 14 soldiers, drivers and pall bearers—attached to the administration branch at the headquarters, has only one task: to ensure that their fallen comrades are received with a ceremony that neatly bypasses civilian red tape and escorted to their loved ones.

The bodies are flown in by civilian airlines at the rate of over one a day to the technical area of the Indian Airlines terminal at Delhi airport. The standard operation procedure is the same for every casualty, from a jawan to a general, and minutely detailed in a way only the army can, from the exact number of personnel to the number of vehicles to be deployed. At the airport, the coffins are received by the group in a specially-manufactured trolley marked with the national flag. A brief ceremony follows in which wreaths are laid by the army chief, army commander



and local military commander and the armymen sound the Last Post and reverse rifles.

The practice originated during the Kargil war when the government decided that all fallen soldiers would be sent back to their families with full military honours, coffins draped in the Tricolour. Even after the cross-border invasion was replaced by cross-border

terrorism and the media glare dimmed, the practice continues. The unit ensures there is no delay in sending the coffins from conflict zones to the bereaved families.

The department doesn't even have a name for fear of affecting the morale of those working in it. It is an emotionally draining job, among the toughest in a peace time army and the men are rotated every month. An officer confesses, "Seeing a child lighting his father's pyre breaks our hearts".

Delhi is the hub for the bodies that come in from India's northern and eastern borders and hosts a majority of the fatalities in the 1.1-million strong army. The bodies are categorised as either a physical casualty (struck down by accidents) or a battle casualty (killed by militants). Both are given the same respect. There is, however, no ceremony for soldiers who commit suicide or kill their comrades. The Tricolour is substituted with a white cloth and there is no ceremonial guard of honour. Even death has its subtleties. ■